

Wide Sargasso Sea

Last part

- Rochester is shocked at finding Antoinette transformed "dull... inflamed" (79)
- Antoinette accuses Rochester of turning her into someone else and practicing obeah (80)
- Her hatred for Rochester for ruining the one place she loved
- Her "murder"[ous] rage & violence – she bites & curses at him, when he tries to restrain her
- Christophine comes to help and Rochester feels like "nightmare," everything is "hostile" "threatening" "menace" that he needs to "protect" himself
- He sees Antoinette "stretched on the bed quite still. Like a doll... marionette quality" (82)

- Confrontation between Christophine & Rochester – black, female, servant versus wealthy white master
- Like a “judge,” she challenges his authority by holding him accountable for being “rough” with her & trying to “break her up”
- She is a Creole servant, but resists the patriarchal and colonial system Antoinette is trapped in
- She reduces him to silence under her control while he silently admits to those charges “But better to say nothing”
- Accuses him of calling her “Marionette” (84)
- But he also becomes a speechless marionette under her influence – his interior monologue reveals his unconscious spoken thoughts
- Christophine begs him to love Antoinette again, which he refuses

- Christophine demands him to return Antoinette's dowry, which Rochester rejects & threatens with the police and the doctor
- Christophine suspects that he is doing that for money and Antoinette will become just like her mother
- Rochester blames his father for not loving him & abandoning him
- But his letter is formal and writes of his return due to "unforeseen circumstances" (134)
- Crowing of the cock
- His scribble – a woman staring out from the attic window

- For Rochester, West Indies is becoming similar to England "so cool, so grey" (91) "no brazen sun... The weather's changed" (92) suggesting his mastery over nature & Antoinette
- Accuses her of being a whore & capable of incest
- He can be seen as the wind that will "break" Antoinette
- "She's mad but mine, mine. For me." (92) - his possessiveness
- On the departure day, Antoinette shows "blank indifference" while he feels "sadness" at the house
- He wants forgiveness but sees only hatred from Antoinette, who has become a living dead, a "ghost" and a "mad girl" (95)

- A boy cries with emotion & Antoinette apologizes with a "doll's voice" with "indifferent voice" (95)
- Rochester's hatred for the place and her "She left me thirsty and all my life would be thirst and longing for what I had lost before I found it" (96)
- "she's one of them. For the day when she is only a memory to be avoided." (96)

Part Three

- Grace Poole's narrative to Leah after the death of Rochester's father and brother
- She is suspicious about the nature of her work but is paid double from Mrs. Eff for her discretion
- Rochester's power over servants is through money
- Grace feels safe but fears Antoinette "in her own darkness" who is "still fierce" and violent (97)

- Antoinette's confusion and terror - questions the reasons for her captivity and abuse
- Absence of the looking glass- she lacks her own identity (98)
- Overhears voices of Grace and Leah
- She believes she lives in a world made of cardboard-unreal, artificial world
- Her imprisonment can be seen similar to slavery, just as ocean voyage recalls slave routes

- Antoinette wakes up aching, with no memory of her brother's visit
- Richard's non-recognition of Antoinette- she has lost her own identity & become Rochester's creation (madwoman)
- Money and time have no meaning for her
- Her red dress is a reminder of her past & who she is "colour of fire and sunset... flamboyant flowers" (symbolizes passion & destruction)
- "life and death kiss" with Sandi, which is seen by Rochester as "intemperate and unchaste." (102)
- The red dress is associated with "fire" and it reminded her of "something I must do"

- Antoinette's third dream – she knocks over the candle in the red room & goes out to the battlement with the red sky
- She sees "the ghost" in the mirror-she sees her objectified image imposed on her by Rochester
- Her candle causes fire and she out for help to Christophine "I had been helped" (104)
- She imagines herself as Coco-confused identity "streamed out like wings" (104)
- She sees Tia beckoning when she is about to jump
- Waking up from her dream, she knows what to do "it burned up again to light me along the dark passage"

The ending?

- Rhys questions single vision in favor of one that opens up many possibilities
 - Ambiguous, open-ended ending - finality of death is replaced with multiple meanings
 - Significance of a dream (dreamlike narrative)
 - fictional reality is important as reality itself
- 1) the only escape from oppression is through insanity & suicide
- But this escape is illusory

- 2) Her setting fire can be seen as a step to reclaim her identity and liberate from imprisonment
- Darkness is illuminated by the light
 - Chooses action & revolt unlike her mother
 - Her process of self-knowledge
 - Her identification with Tia and Christophine – rejection of white Creole for black Caribbean identity? (but it could just be wish for longed-union)
 - Jump can be seen as rebirth, according to the myth of flamboyant flower (tree of life)

Issues

- What does Rhys accomplish by rewriting Bronte's novel?
- Post-colonial approach? How does Rhys present white/black, master/slave, England/West Indies binaries?
- Theme of identity & oppression (mutually reinforcing forces of gender, class, race etc)
- Narrative Form & Strategies (advantages?)
- Symbols & Imagery